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The West Africa Unique Identification for Regional Integration and Inclusion (WURI) Program:

Unique Identifiers to Enable Access to Human Development Services

READ THIS IF: you are interested in how unique identifiers can enable access to human development services across multiple countries and institutional contexts

Problem:
Overcoming barriers to delivering social services and exclusion of people who lack government recognized unique identifiers in West Africa

Tool:
Biometric data; biographic data; QR codes; interoperable data

Solution:
Using a minimal, human-centered design, issuing a basic unique identifier that is interoperable across participating ECOWAS member states, to all persons physically present in the territory

- **TIMELINE:** WURI launched in 2018 as a regional Multiphase Programmatic Approach (MPA) operation with credits and grants to Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea and a grant to the ECOWAS Commission in Phase 1; it expanded with credits and grants to Benin, Burkina Faso, Niger, and Togo in Phase 2 in 2020. The program is slated to run through 2028.

Introduction

Access to basic human development programs in West Africa is particularly low. Individually, the sub-region's countries perform poorly on the Human Capital Index (HCI).[1] It is the second-lowest African region in rank for social safety net coverage (Beegle, Coudouel and Monsalve 2018). By contrast, the sub-region has the second highest transaction value of mobile money on the continent (GSMA 2018).

Accessing services and benefits is often difficult and burdensome due to identification barriers, especially for the poorest and most vulnerable, who tend both to be excluded and denied access, and yet who also tend to be most in need of those very services and benefits, be they public or private. Difficulty verifying such individuals' identities represents a significant obstacle to accessing services (Daly, George, and Ariss 2021; Hamner, Esquivel-Korsiak, and Pande 2021).

In the area covered by the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), around 53 percent of the population were unregistered and lacked proof of identification (World Bank 2018). This amounted to about 196 million people and posed an

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[1] The HCI measures the human capital of the next generation, defined, on the basis of three components (survival; expected years of learning-adjusted school; and health), as the amount of human capital that a child born today can expect to achieve in view of the risks of poor health and education prevailing in the country where that child lives. WURI countries fare poorly on the index, which ranges from 0 to 1: Benin (0.40), Burkina Faso (0.38), Côte d'Ivoire (0.38), Guinea (0.37), Niger (0.32), and Togo (0.43). See World Bank 2020.

important challenge for governments in the region.

This case study examines the West Africa Unique Identification for Regional Integration and Inclusion (WURI)[2] Program, which aims to confront this challenge head-on. In 2022, the program was working in six countries across two phases in partnership with the governments of Benin, Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Niger, and Togo, and with the ECOWAS Commission.

WURI leverages disruptive and transformative technologies to amplify the impact of the program by linking biometrically verified foundational identification (*f*ID) credentials to each individual choosing to register, allowing service providers to verify the unique identity of their users, and, at the same time, allowing *f*ID credential holders to easily authenticate themselves using digitally signed QR codes. This case study examines how WURI was implemented and scaled up. It seeks to examine how WURI leveraged data, technology, and data governance to reach its goals, and key successes and enablers in this effort.

Human Development Problem Confronted

Across West Africa and the ECOWAS sub-region, people lack access to services, particularly those that bear on "the main ingredients of next generation's human capital—defined as survival, schooling and health" (World Bank 2018). Lack of access to the right to identification very frequently impedes access to services, as identification credentials are often required. Widespread lack of registration thus presents a real barrier. Niger provides one striking example of this challenge: 55 percent of the population aged 15 and above and about one-third of children still lack a government-recognized proof of unique identity (World Bank 2020). At the same time, these issues have profound impacts for access to health services, social protection programs, and their effectiveness.

Tackling the Human Development Challenge

The WURI program was initiated in 2018. At launch, two countries were involved, Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea, along with the ECOWAS Commission. In 2020, a second phase of the project launched, bringing in Benin, Burkina Faso, Niger, and Togo. The project is providing financing of US$395.1 million (Phase 1 and 2).

Drawing on a human-centered design approach, WURI focuses on addressing impediments to accessing human development services due to lack of identity credentials.[3] It works with participating governments to create *f*ID systems that will register individuals and issue basic, digitally signed credentials with QR codes to verify their unique identity. WURI begins with processes of strengthening the legal and institutional framework by building administrative and technical skills and capacity, as well as social safeguards, communications, grievance redress, and data governance, including data protection. All participating WURI countries have existing data protection and cybersecurity laws, and support is offered to bolster their institutional capacities in this area.

Designs are drawn up for *en masse* registration of all persons in the territory, with priority for the poor and vulnerable in rural and remote areas. Social inclusion plans and stakeholder consultations are run to understand needs and to mitigate concerns of various groups, particularly those most at risk of exclusion. Communications strategies are developed to address concerns and apprehensions, including that of data protection and cybersecurity.

In parallel, tender documents are issued to procure systems integrators to deploy a foundational identification platform and biometric data collection kits. Additionally, a registration service provider is procured for outreach across the territory to register individuals, as well as a communications firm for nation-wide messaging through various channels.

[2] *Wuri* is also the name of a counting game, a version of mancala, played in West Africa. In a cross-linguistic play on words, then, WURI intends to "make everybody count."

[3] Human-centered design is a multidisciplinary approach that focuses on the experiences, characteristics, and needs of the people who are end-users of a given intervention. See Daly, George Karippacheril, and Ariss 2021; Lindert, George Karippacheril, and Rodríguez Caillava 2020.

A registration campaign is organized to collect data and to issue digitally signed unique *f*ID credentials as QR codes on paper. As the *f*ID credentials are also digital certificates, they can also be loaded onto mobile phones.

Once credentials have been issued to target populations (based on the physical presence of individuals in a country's territory, not on nationality, residency, or other potentially exclusive legal criteria) these then allow for "linking *f*ID systems to safety net programs and social registries, health and pension programs, financial inclusion, women's inclusion and empowerment and labor mobility" (World Bank 2018). These *f*ID systems are intended to be interoperable across ECOWAS member states, an important factor in a region where there is significant intra-regional mobility. This includes routine travel to conduct trade, which might be done on a daily or seasonal basis. The ECOWAS sub-region is also home to nomadic and pastoral populations as well as to groups with ethnic and familial ties stretching across national borders. Interoperability of these unique identity credentials is critical for inclusion in states that are affected by dynamics of conflict, displacement, and fragility.

The credential that will be issued with support from WURI is basic and minimal by design – that is, it associates only "minimal biographic data" with that biometric information needed to "provide assurance of a person's unique identity ('I am who I say I am'), and nothing more" (World Bank 2020). Critically, this association is not connected with nationality or other questions of legal status.[4] This is by design, as it allows for both greater inclusion and better data governance. From an operational standpoint, minimizing the amount of information or documents collected removes potential barriers for people who are seeking to register. It also speeds up the process of registration, allowing for operational efficiencies. From a data protection perspective, it supports the principles of data minimization and purpose or use limitation.

In each country, the program works in the context of specific country-level reforms, including identification and data protection laws and the construction of local technology platforms.

Technology Selection

An important technological angle for WURI is the linking of *biometric information to unique identifiers* for each person. This enables service providers to verify that a person is who they say they are at the point of service, as well as for online and cross-border services.

The underlying technology is relatively simple. The base of the system is the assignment of a unique number. This unique identifier is linked to an individual, and biometric information (in practice, fingerprints and in some cases iris scans) is used to verify the identity of this individual and to ensure that one number corresponds to one individual. Leveraging biometric information also ensures the stability of this information over time, since biometric markers typically stay the same throughout a person's life. In the case of biometric failure, protocols are being developed to ensure that the person might still access services.

Once a unique identifier is assigned to an individual, they can use a variety of simple technologies to provide proof of their unique identity. At its most simple form, they can simply remember their number. This number is also encoded in a QR code, which contains biographic information and photo for verification in offline environments. These QR codes can be read using a standardized mobile app or a QR code reader. Since WURI's launch, some countries have made significant progress in this area (for example, Benin has issued 3 million *f*ID credentials with QR codes, many of which have been issued online, and has registered close to 97 percent of the population).

An additional key aspect of the program is ensuring data protection and cybersecurity. This is connected,

[4] The Program was approved to facilitate access to services by financing the development of foundational identification (*f*ID) systems, which would allow all persons physically in the territory of a participating country, irrespective of, and without accounting for, nationality, legal status or residency, to receive a government-recognized unique identity credential. (World Bank 2020).

first, with the legal framework, ensuring that the appropriate legal provisions—both in the law as well as in the associated regulatory instruments—provide adequate guarantees and controls. It also connects to the relevant institutional arrangements, in terms of ensuring institutional architecture that accommodates existing technology, while remaining open to technological developments. A clear separation is drawn between service delivery mandates and security concerns. Moreover, as the program relies on the broad question of building trust between the state and individuals and communities, careful attention is given to ensuring that people have confidence in the collecting authorities to protect, secure, and appropriately use their data, and thus willing to consent. This issue was addressed through supporting the drafting of legislation and regulations that would implement robust protections for data, and that would ensure that data collected was minimal. The *f*ID system—and the data collected—is to be administered by an independent, specially created authority; registration is voluntary, and consent is required from individuals to collect their data; the numbers issued themselves are unique, random, and last for life. WURI also provides capacity support for relevant agencies such as the data protection authority and cybersecurity agency.

Institutional Alignment for Change

WURI works at both a regional level, and at a national level working with each of the six participating governments. WURI's goals are aligned with ECOWAS provisions on freedom of movement and regional integration. At the national level, the World Bank coordinates with each state to work with specific legal frameworks around civil registration and access to services. This includes ongoing identification reforms and new laws, and registration drives targeting people currently without government-issued identification. The program seeks to complement existing systems, not to create competition.

Lessons

The WURI experience to date suggests important lessons for how unique identifiers can be leveraged to overcome barriers to human development service delivery and promote inclusion. These may be particularly important for complex institutional and political contexts, in which a wide variety of stakeholders from multiple countries are involved.

1. Take into account institutional diversity and diversity of experience and practice. This was a particularly important aspect of WURI. Each country participating in WURI started from a different point, in terms of experiences with existing technologies, with data and technology initiatives, with institutional dynamics, and with capacities for universal registration of people. This meant that it was vital to work with countries to both address their specific goals, and to ensure alignment so that countries moved forward toward the same broad goal together. To accomplish this, early experiences suggested the importance of facilitating learning among and across the countries working on WURI. The diversity of national experiences meant that each country's representatives had valuable experiences to share among their peers, and this enabled them to progress in the project while learning from one another about a variety of technical issues. Client ministry staff make use of freely available communications technologies to help facilitate natural flows of shared experience, to exchange tips on how to tackle obstacles, and to build moral support.

2. Assemble a diverse team and cultivate a cohesive sense of shared purpose. Building a strong team, that is tied together by a shared spirit or esprit de corps that could keep operational team members motivated, also proved important. Across the six countries, the World Bank has a team of more than 20 staff and consultants drawn from various sectors supporting technical capacity building and operations. Interviews with the project team highlighted the importance of building teams with a variety of perspectives and skill sets. They highlighted the importance of diversity and of thinking outside of the box, with important skills including occupations as diverse as lawyers, economists, technologists, sociologists, governance and human development specialists, and among others, to ensure that a wide variety of relevant skills could be deployed for an interdisciplinary approach to problem solving.

3. Ensure inclusion by design. Inclusion is built into the heart of WURI. Efforts to ensure this included extensive focus on how users would access human development services and to ensure that users would feel comfortable and have incentives to provide their data in order to gain access to services. By design, WURI registration exercises and issuing of credentials commence in rural and peripheral areas, moving into urban areas and the national capital. Minimal requirements for the credential were seen as a key driver of initial success.

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